

Session 9: Remembrance as Participation

Key Takeaways

- Paul has both freedom and rights as an apostle, but his goal is not to express his personal freedom in a way that thwarts or harms others.
- The Corinthians are free to follow their consciences in these matters, with love as the qualifying principle guiding their actions in difficult situations.
- Understood in context, [1 Corinthians 10:13](#) describes the temptation of idolatry.

Freedom and Rights

[1 Corinthians 9](#) comes in between the discussion on idols in [chapters 8 and 10](#). Paul makes the point that he has both freedom and rights as an apostle, but he doesn't use any of them. This is in contrast to the Corinthians who think they are free to do what they want and are entitled.

1 Corinthians 9:12b NIV

But we did not use this right. On the contrary, we put up with anything rather than hinder the gospel of Christ.

Paul does everything “for the sake of the gospel.” He keeps himself free from the Corinthians having any hold over him through their patronage.

The Story of Israel: A Type

In [1 Corinthians 10](#), Paul connects idolatry, sexual immorality, and forsaking God. He also connects the Corinthians back to the Israelites through the themes of baptism, spiritual food and drink, and Christ. They are not merely examples, but “types” (Greek: *τύποι*)—more like forerunners. They are people who have come before to whom the Christians in Corinth are connected by being in Christ.

These things are written down as “warnings” for us.

Mary Patton Baker builds on Frances Young's reading of the reference to Israel as a *typos* to make the point that the Israelites act as a parable or pattern that we remember in order to copy. It has a “mimetic quality” (Young, 1997).

“In light of Young's explanation of typological mimesis, a typological pattern for worship emerges from the Israelites' sacrificial worship: repentance, self-offering, remembrance, and thanksgiving for atonement, resulting in communion. One can begin to see how the celebration of the Eucharist fulfills Israel's multiple modes of sacrificial worship.”

Patton Baker, Mary (2014). "Participating in the Body and Blood of Christ." [*"In Christ" in Paul: Explorations in Paul's Theology of Union and Participation*](#). Eerdmans. 518.

Paul sees remembrance as participatory.

"The Jewish people understood remembrance as a way of appropriating stories of God's salvific acts into the present to affirm his presence and power in their lives."

Patton Baker, Mary (2014). "Participating in the Body and Blood of Christ." [*"In Christ" in Paul: Explorations in Paul's Theology of Union and Participation*](#). Eerdmans. 520.

Parallel Between the Israelites and the Corinthians

In this context, Paul writes [1 Corinthians 10:3](#).

1 Corinthians 10:13 NIV

No temptation has overtaken you except what is common to mankind. And God is faithful; he will not let you be tempted beyond what you can bear. But when you are tempted, he will also provide a way out so that you can endure it.

Then, in [1 Corinthians 10:14-22](#), Paul turns to the idea of what they, the Corinthians "participate" in. He uses two terms, the verb *μετέχω* (Greek: *metechó*—to partake of, share in) and the noun *κοινωνία* (participants, fellow partakers).

- The cup of blessing is a participation in the blood of Christ, and the bread a participation in his body ([v. 16](#)).
- We "partake" (Greek: *μετέχω*) of one loaf ([v. 17](#)).
- Those who eat the sacrifices are "fellow partakers" (Greek: *κοινωνοί*) in the altar ([v. 18](#)).
- Paul does not want them to be "fellow partakers" with demons ([v. 20](#)).
- You are not able to drink the cup of the Lord and the cup of demons, nor "partake" in the table of the Lord and the table of demons ([v. 21](#)).

Another Quotation?

Michael Gorman thinks there may be another quotation in [1 Corinthians 10:29b](#).

"On the other hand, 10:29b may be the beginning of Paul's (final) summary, and he may again be quoting the libertine Corinthian position, only finally to refute it with the string of maxims in [10:31-33](#)."

Gorman, Michael (2004). [*Apostle of the Crucified Lord*](#). Eerdmans. 40.

Reflection Question

[1 Corinthians 10:13](#) is often lifted from its context and read as a comment on temptation in general. How does the context of Paul's argument add nuance to this verse? How do you understand the verse in light of its context?